Where Does Criticism End?

A Latent-Variable Map of Antisemitic Attitudes

IN ONE LINE

We built a survey method that checks, one statement at a time and with rules fixed in advance, how closely agreeing with a statement about Israel goes together with agreeing with classic stereotypes about Jews, without taking a side in the debate over where criticism ends.

THE PROBLEM

Whether, and when, negative attitudes toward Israel reflect hostility toward Jews is sharply contested, and the answer shapes campus policy, law and how incidents are counted. Three widely cited definitions (the IHRA working definition, the Jerusalem Declaration and the Nexus Document) draw the line in different places. What ought to be called antisemitic is a question of values that no survey can settle, but each position also rests on factual claims about how attitudes fit together, and those can be tested. Without a transparent, shared way to test them, each side can simply cite the evidence that suits it.

WHAT WE BUILT

- **A map of attitudes** (a "bifactor" survey model). Respondents rate classic stereotypes about Jews and a range of statements about Israel. For each Israel statement, the model estimates how much of the pattern in people's answers it shares with the stereotypes, rather than only with other Israel statements.
- **In, out, or undetermined.** Each statement is compared with a threshold fixed before any data are seen and reported as in, out or undetermined, so uncertainty is shown, not hidden. The same rule applies to every statement, and every result is published whichever side it appears to favour.
- **Fair comparisons.** Tests for whether groups (by politics, age or country) read a statement differently, and a "list experiment" that lets people answer sensitive questions more privately, to check whether direct answers are shaded.
- **Local estimates, and a caution.** Methods to estimate regional attitudes from national samples, and a demonstration that simple "how many stereotypes does a person agree with" indices can rank groups in the wrong order.

WHAT OUR SIMULATIONS SHOW

All results come from computer-simulated survey answers in which we know the true answer.

- **The map can be recovered when the design is rich enough.** With six Israel statements and 3,000 respondents, no statement was placed on the wrong side of the threshold; statements close to it were more often left "undetermined".
- **Too few or too similar statements make the map impossible to draw,** and standard software can still report success with meaningless answers. Agreement between repeated fitting runs caught only one of three such cases; a diagnostic we added caught all three.
- **Hidden survey problems can push results either way.** A tendency to agree with any statement, and Israel statements that echo classic tropes, moved some statements' results up and others down until they were modelled. They also exposed a flaw in our own draft plan (a screening step that missed one kind of group difference), which we fixed and re-tested.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

STATUS **A methods paper, with no real-world findings.** No real attitudes have been measured yet: we have fielded no survey, so nothing here says whether any statement about Israel is antisemitic, or describes the views of any group. The method does not pick a definition or judge individuals; it proposes how to measure these attitudes responsibly, as a tool equally usable, and equally checkable, by people on every side of the definitions debate.

WHAT WOULD COME NEXT

A U.S. online survey of about 6,000 adults, after cognitive interviews and a pilot, with the statements, threshold and decision rules registered publicly before fieldwork and reviewed by advisers who hold opposing views of the definitions. Results will be published statement by statement, and no output will describe any definition as validated or refuted.

Kornstein Lab for Antisemitism Research · November 2026 · Drafted with substantial AI assistance (Anthropic's Claude), directed and reviewed by the lab; full paper and code available on request.